Focus and Morning Screen Time in Secondary Classrooms

A report prepared by Amina Yusuf for the Grade 10 reading programme, Term 2.

Introduction

Many teachers at our school believe that students arrive already tired. They say that students spend the first hour of the school day unable to settle into a task. This report looks at whether the phone a student holds in the morning has anything to do with that. The question matters because our staff meeting has to decide whether to adopt a phone basket policy before the next term begins, and nobody wants to make that decision on a feeling.

What we did

Between 4 March and 22 March, I asked 74 students in three Grade 10 classes to fill a short paper form each morning for two weeks. The form asked one question about the previous evening: how many minutes of phone use after the last lesson. It asked one question that morning: how hard it was to concentrate during the first period, on a scale from 1 to 5. I collected 61 completed forms. The remaining 13 were not returned, mostly on Fridays.

What the forms show

Students who reported more than ninety minutes of phone use after the last lesson marked their concentration as 4 or 5 (hard) on 71% of mornings. Students who reported less than thirty minutes marked 4 or 5 on 34% of mornings. This is the clearest pattern in the data, and it is the reason I recommend a trial of the phone basket policy rather than a full rule.

The pattern is not proof. The students who used phones longest were also the students who stayed up latest, and the two effects cannot be separated with the data I collected. Some students also told me they wrote the numbers from memory rather than from any record. Sleep itself was never measured.

The second finding

Concentration improved across the two weeks for almost every group, including the heavy-use group. This suggests that the beginning of term was doing something on its own: the classes were still settling into a new timetable, and the first week always looks worse than the third.

Teachers clearly know this already. Everybody knows that a new timetable is hard.

What I recommend

Trial the phone basket policy in one Grade 10 class for four weeks starting in Term 3.

Measure sleep directly, using the school's existing wellbeing questionnaire, so the two effects can be separated.

Ask students to record their phone minutes from the device's own screen-time report instead of from memory.

Repeat the survey with all four Grade 10 classes so the result is not standing on 61 forms.

The teaching staff should decide whether this is worth the morning supervision cost. I have not measured that cost, and the report does not claim that the policy will improve grades. Improved concentration is the only outcome examined here, and it is a narrow claim.

Sources

No external sources were consulted for this report. The figures come from the paper forms collected at the school.